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NARRATING POLITICAL RECONCILIATION: TRUTH AND RECONCILIATION IN SOUTH AFRICA

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ABSTRACT

This article enquires into the narration of reconciliation in South Africa and its political implications. It scrutinizes the subjects, objects and material practices that flow from the reconciliation story. The investigation turns on two crucial assumptions: (a) that discourse is an ideological system of meaning that constitutes and naturalizes the subjects and objects of political life, and (b) that narrative is a special discursive form, the structural features of which have specific political effects that are not illuminated by a more general discourse analytic approach. A narrative perspective is important because the TRC explicitly undertook the task of telling a story about South Africa's transition from past violence to future reconciliation, and argued that storytelling was fundamental to catharsis, healing, and reconciliation on an individual and a national level. Narrative theory renders more specifically applicable some of the general claims of political discourse analysis; while the insights of political discourse analysis highlight the political contexts and effects of governing narratives to which most narrative theory, on its own, is blind. The combination of these two theoretical premises furnishes a powerful approach to understanding the story about reconciliation told by the TRC, and its political implications.

KEY WORDS

discourse; Foucault; narrative; reconciliation; South Africa; TRC; truth

Men . . . to make sense of their span . . . need fictive concords with origins and ends, such as give meaning to lives. *Frank Kermode*

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INTRODUCTION

THE ADVENT of South Africa's Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) in 1995 was a striking paradigmatic moment in the development of what has since emerged as a burgeoning industry, both in theory and praxis, as the politics of reconciliation. Since the TRC's highly publicized operation, reconciliation is now a popular and widespread discourse governing the various contexts within which regime change or transition from conflict occurs, from cases as diverse as Northern Ireland and Peru.

Reconciliatory political processes have emerged out of particular and controversial predicaments. Symptomatic of the various transitional contexts within which the call for redress of human rights violations has been made, reconciliation is pitched between attempts to answer to the 'moral demands of justice' and the 'political demands of peace'. Consequently, reconciliatory projects are hostage to configurations of political power that condition the terms of peace agreements, underscore the legitimacy of incoming regimes and perform a nation-building function. The unfolding of South Africa's reconciliation experience has prompted critical reflection upon its political constraints, its limitations and exclusions (Mamdani, 1998; Natrass, 1999; Wilson, 2001; Humphrey, 2002; Ross, 2003). This article aims to further critical reflection by developing a theoretical framework through which to think the limits and exclusions of reconciliation. In so doing, it seeks recourse to a discourse analytic method in order to think through the politics of reconciliation in South Africa, to scrutinize the subjects, objects and material practices that flow from its reconciliatory narrative in order to illuminate the politics inherent in such a project.

This investigation of the TRC turns on two crucial assumptions. The first is that *discourse* constitutes and naturalizes the subjects and objects of political life. In describing the implications of this assumption I draw upon the work of Michel Foucault and Louis Althusser.

My second and related assumption is that *narrative* is a special discursive form, the structural features of which have specific political effects that are not illuminated by a more general discourse analytic approach. In making this argument extant I shall draw upon two key theorists of narrative: Hayden White and Frank Kermode. A narrative perspective is important because the TRC explicitly undertook the task of telling a story about South Africa's transition from past violence to future reconciliation, and argued that storytelling was fundamental to catharsis, healing, and reconciliation on an individual and a national level.

The invocation of narrative theory fleshes out and renders more specifically applicable some of the general claims of political discourse analysis; while the insights of political discourse analysis highlight the political contexts and effects of governing narratives to which most narrative theory, on its own, is blind. The combination of these two theoretical premises, each supplementing the other, furnishes, I argue, a uniquely appropriate and powerful approach to understanding the story about reconciliation told by the TRC and its particular political effects.

POLITICAL DISCOURSE ANALYSIS

Foucault's (1973, 1977, 1978) 'archaeological' method seeks, first, to historicize the emergence of specific discourses over time and account for the way in which certain discourses become powerful, binding, and sustained at particular historical junctures. In a second and related feature of his analysis, Foucault shows how discourses discipline subject positions within a constellation of power relations. For Foucault, discourse is constitutive of, and materialized through, social and political relations and identities which are embedded within, and emerge via, non-discursive practices such as institutions and policies. For example, medical discourse disciplines places 'patient' and 'doctor' and legal discourses 'judge' and 'criminal' within a specific and hierarchical relationship governed by institutional forces.

Foucault analyses the sets of statements, or discourses, which constitute powerful claims to truth by societies at certain points in time and identifies the rules of formation governing their appearance. He describes the emergence of, and the relations between, particular statements within specific historical contexts and is concerned with the connection between 'discursive practices' and 'non-discursive' activities and institutions. In drawing out this connection, Foucault (1972) details the way in which 'discursive formations' comprise four constituent aspects:

1. The *objects* about which statements are made;
2. The *enunciative modalities* or positions from which subjects speak;
3. The *concepts* which govern discourse;
4. The *strategies* or *theories* that flow from particular discursive formations.

These four aspects comprise the particular *rules* governing a discourse and are constitutive of the authority, indeed hegemony, of a discourse at a particular point in time. The four rules provide a fruitful locus of analysis of South Africa's reconciliation discourse in the following ways:

THE OBJECTS OF THE TRC

First, Foucault (1972) accounts for the construction of objects within discourse 'by relating them to the body of rules that enable them to form as objects of a discourse and thus constitute the conditions of their historical appearance' (p. 48). The first of these rules comprises the social relations in which certain practices or symptoms ('neurosis', 'psychosis', or 'dementia') become the objects of scientific (medical) investigation. The second set of rules consists of the 'authorities of delimitation' invested with the power to adjudicate to which discursive formation certain objects belong.

Foucault argues that discursive practices *constitute* their objects of enquiry rather than the objects of enquiry being *prior* to the discourses that 'contain' them. As such, his arguments help to elucidate an account of the contingency of the TRC's story about the past, which in turn attests to the political context in which the 'truth' about South Africa's violent history was (re)constructed.

The TRC designated 'gross violations of human rights' perpetrated by all parties to South Africa's violent political struggle between 1960 and 1994 as the objects of its investigations. In so doing, it identified, defined, and quantified precisely which categories of violations were central to its investigations, such as 'killing', 'torture', 'abduction', 'severe ill treatment' and so on. It placed a further limitation on which violations were to be investigated by stating that only violations perpetrated with a 'political objective' could qualify as a gross violation of human rights and thus be legitimate objects of investigation.

The 'authorities of delimitation' were not simply restricted to the officials of the TRC but can be traced back to the actors engaged in the peace negotiations in the early 1990s, primarily members of the National Party (NP) and the African National Congress (ANC). Specifically, the NP insisted upon the provision of amnesty in return for 'the truth' about past violations, and argued that all parties to the conflict should be subject to scrutiny. As a result, 'violations perpetrated with a political objective' were delimited as the common denominator around which a multi-party scrutiny could take place. This in turn meant that responsibility for violations would not appear to be the sole preserve of the former regime but would be apportioned to all political parties who had utilized violent means of waging their campaigns.

The political effects of this delimitation were to elide other histories of South Africa which may have claimed to be equally 'true' and 'complete' without rendering an account of politically motivated violations. Prior to the ascendancy of international discourses on human rights that shaped South Africa's reconciliatory process, no one would have seen the history of South Africa as a history of 'human rights violations'; not the National Party nor the security forces, of course, but neither the ANC nor much of the black majority who might instead have narrated South Africa's history of oppression, exploitation, cruelty, just war, or revolution. Significantly, structural violence was crucial to apartheid's project of 'separate development' and was not included in the TRC's appraisal of past violations of human rights. Yet many thousands more people were victims of such structural violations than of the political violations it sought to compensate and 'reconcile'.

The notion of 'a human rights violation' in this context is thus an example of a discursively constructed object in the Foucauldian sense, in that it is defined by its place within a discourse which is circumscribed by the social, political, and historical conditions of its emergence.

ENUNCIATIVE MODALITIES OF THE TRC

Second, Foucault describes the appearance of the subjects of discourse as a function of 'enunciative modalities'. This refers to the way in which certain subjects of a discourse are endowed with the authority to speak, often because of their recognized training and concomitant 'expertise', such as judges and doctors. The authority of their declarations is constituted by two

things: the institutional site, and the authorized professional position from which they speak. Truth claims are an effect of the declarations of subjects empowered to make authoritative statements (Foucault, 1972: 50–5).¹ Subjects do not independently produce, but are constituted by, discourse, and they in turn reproduce the particular assumptions of the discourse within which they are constituted, thus ensuring its hegemony and continuity and also, crucially, the invisibility of its reproduction.

The enunciative modalities of the TRC's discourse are made evident by its designation of the subject positions of 'victim' and 'perpetrator', authorized to speak the 'truth about the past'. Victims and perpetrators were elected as the key agents and witnesses of South Africa's history of 'human rights violations'. The force of 'truth' was endowed upon those testifying by the institutional site of their declarations, the TRC.

Notably, 'victim' and 'perpetrator' constitute the subject positions from which authoritative and binding statements about South Africa's violent past were made, but these are over-determined subjects that are not exclusive or fundamental but are contingent upon the new narrative about past violence. Given that the constitution of 'victim' and 'perpetrator' is an effect of the TRC's *particular* historicization of the South Africa's apartheid past, it is probable that under different political circumstances these subject positions would have been occupied by different individuals. If, for example, the ANC had been fully able to dictate the terms of the transition and had held members of the former regime to account at a criminal tribunal, it is unlikely that ANC members would have been identified as 'perpetrators'. Or perhaps an investigation might have also enquired into the 'bystanders' and the 'beneficiaries' of apartheid, thus adding further categories of subjection. As such, different subjects would be assigned the 'authority' to speak by virtue of their constitution within another politico-historical discourse about the past.

A further and specific account of subjectivity is rendered by Foucault in the *History of Sexuality* (1978) that is of special relevance here. Foucault explores human subjection as a function of the confessional (pp. 58–63).² Through the confessional, human agents are implicated in their own subjection, such that subjection appears to be 'voluntary', or even willed. The confessional is an invisible function of power and domination such that 'the obligation to confess is now relayed through so many different points . . . that we no longer perceive it as the effect of a power that constrains us' (p. 60). As such, 'perpetrators' appear to collude in their own subjection as perpetrators by performing a public ritual of confession to the TRC – as, indeed, do victims collude in their own subjection as 'victims' by 'bearing witness' to suffering.

CONCEPTS OF THE TRC

Third, Foucault (1972: 56) outlines the set of rules governing the production of 'concepts' within a discourse that is comprised of a 'field of statements' governed by rules which stipulate the proper order of appearance and

relation between the respective concepts and are constitutive of the 'reality' they claim to reflect.

Foucault's understanding of the workings of 'concepts' can be usefully applied to understanding the way in which the official discourse of the TRC organized human rights violations into sets and subsets by a 'coding frame', the purpose of which was to systematically taxonomize and quantify 'gross violations of human rights' (see Table 1).

Following this broad categorization, each HRV (human rights violation) category is broken down into further, more detailed subsets. 'Killing', 'torture', 'severe ill treatment', as shown in Table 2.

TABLE 1
Coding Frame for Gross Violations of Human Rights

HRV* Category	Code	Definition
Killing	KILLING	A killing is when a person dies, in one of three ways: • Assassination is the killing of a <i>targeted person</i> by a person or group who <i>developed a secret plan or plot</i> to achieve this. A person is targeted because of their political position. • Execution is capital punishment (death sentence) imposed and carried out by a legal or authorized body such as court of law or tribunal. Victim is aware of death sentence. Perpetrators are the state, homeland governments, or security structures of political movements. • Killing is all other deaths, including a killing by a crowd of people.
Torture	TORTURE	Torture happens in <i>captivity</i> or in <i>custody</i> of any kind, formal or informal (for example, prisons, police cells, detention camps, private houses, containers, or anywhere while the individual is tied up or bound to something). Torture is usually used to get information, or to force the person to do something (for example, admit to a crime, or sign a statement), but it is also used for punishment, degradation, and systematic breakdown of an individual. It includes mental or psychological torture (for example, witnessing torture, or telling the person that their family is dead).

TABLE 1
Continued

<i>HRV* Category</i>	<i>Code</i>	<i>Definition</i>
Severe ill treatment	SEVERE	Severe ill treatment covers attempted killing and all forms of inflicted suffering causing <i>extreme</i> bodily and/or mental harm. It tends to take place outside of custody (for example, injury by a car bomb, or assault at a rally), but a person can be subjected to severe ill treatment in custody too (for example, a single server beating, or tear gas in the cell).
Abduction	ABDUCTION	Abduction is when a person is forcibly and illegally taken away (for example, kidnapping). It does <i>not</i> mean detention or arrest. Arrest is not a gross violation of human rights (see <i>associated violations</i>). If the person is never found again, it is a disappearance.

* HRV = 'human rights violation'.

Source: Truth and Reconciliation Commission (1998: Volume 5, Appendix 1)

TABLE 2
Coding Frame for Gross Violations of Human Rights

<i>Killing</i>	<i>Code</i>	<i>Definition</i>
Beaten to death	BEATING	Beaten to death by being hit, kicked, punched, specifying description of part of body assaulted, if known (e.g. feet, face, head, genitals, breasts), or object used (e.g. sjambok, baton, gun, rifle, stick, rope, whip, plank, beat against wall).
Burnt to death	BURNING	Killed in a fire or burnt to death using petrol, chemicals, fire, scalding, arson. This does <i>not</i> include 'necklacing' or petrol bombing.
Killed by poison, drugs or chemicals	CHEMICALS	Killed by poison, drugs, or household substance such as bleach or drain cleaner.

Source: Truth and Reconciliation Commission (1998: Volume 5, Appendix 1)

A further 15 categories of 'killing' are delineated in addition to 13 categories of 'torture', 16 categories of 'severe ill treatment', two of 'abduction' and 14 of 'associated violations'. The coding frame was used to organize, categorize, and hierarchize the details of tens of thousands of testimonies which were then fed into the TRC's Information Management System *Infocomm*.

The political effect of this categorization was to synthesize divergent testimonies about the past around the narration of related violations, and to construct human rights violations as occurring within a 'political context' which was concordant with the overall historical narrative about past violence that the TRC wished to tell – that is, as occurring within the framework of party political violence. For example, the description of 'killing' explicitly invokes the *political* contexts within which killing occurs and speaks of 'targeted persons', 'plots', 'plans', 'assassinations' and 'capital punishment'.

The disciplinary effects of this categorization are well illustrated by an imaginative inversion. By substituting 'murder' for 'killing' an assertion of *individual* agency and accountability for violations is more powerfully evoked, which might legitimize a *retributive* process, rather than the *restorative* one favoured by the TRC.

STRATEGIES OF THE TRC

A fourth set of rules describes the way in which certain 'strategies', themes or theories flow from a particular discourse and which are comprised of the organization of the objects, types of enunciation, and concepts (Foucault, 1972: 64).

Reconciliation in South Africa was a strategy of political transition that derived its authority from its construction of the objects, subjects and concepts of the discourse and the sites from which it was articulated. It engaged particular constellations of speaking authorities, evidence bases and concepts such that other interventions were excluded or quite simply never emerged. For example, reconciliation organized the subjects (victims and perpetrators), objects (human rights violations), types of enunciation (confessional and testimonial), and concepts (types of violations, truth, reconciliation) in relationship to one another. The effect of this organization was to allow specific acts of reconciliation to emerge by providing a general template-script of what reconciliation should consist of and involve, that is, confession, testimony, forgiveness, amnesty, and so on, into which particular individuals could fit themselves as reconciled 'victims' and 'perpetrators'. However, the TRC did not make it possible, nor provide a language within which people could say 'I am not reconciled', or 'I do not forgive you', or 'I want you to be punished', or 'I do not confess or apologize for what I did', or 'I do not recognize this process'. It did not recognize non-reconciled outcomes as possibilities.

We can also use Foucault's analysis to point to a 'failure' of reconciliation on the part of the TRC. Particular instances of reconciliation, such as individual 'reconciliation events' would seem perfectly illustrative of Foucault's

general account of 'strategies'. Yet the TRC did not provide the official forum through which victim–perpetrator encounters could be enacted.

In sum, Foucault's work facilitates an account of reconciliation as an intrinsically political project that is constitutive of power, truth, and subjectivity. Reconciliation discourse, by constituting its objects, subjects, concepts, and strategies, governs the production of knowledge and statements of 'fact' and 'value' and maps out the relations of power between those subjected to, and constituted by, its disciplinary force.

To Foucault's account, I want to add a consideration of Louis Althusser's work on ideology and subjectivity. Althusser's formulation of ideology as an element of the 'state apparatus' represents a more compelling (for this study) account of the institutionalization of power than that rendered by Foucault, for whom power emanates from a diffuse and intricate network of locations. As Slavoj Žižek (1994) notes, Althusser's ISA (Ideological State Apparatus), in order to be able to call into being the individual, 'always-already presupposes the massive presence of the state' (p. 13). Žižek argues that by contrast, Foucault fails to engage with 'ideology' as power which means that he cannot draw out the concrete mechanisms of power's workings.³ Nevertheless the continuities and resonances joining Foucault's account of 'discourse' to Althusser's of 'ideology' are suggestive and taken together, they can provide a complementary account of the political workings of discourse.⁴ Thus Althusser (1993) accounts more forcefully than Foucault for the production of subjectivity as an effect of centralized power, of special relevance to an interpretation of the political performance of the TRC.

For Althusser, ideology is not independent of or apart from the social world, nor does it simply reflect its 'realities'. Rather, ideology is constitutive of society in that it produces material effects, important among which is the construction of human subjectivity. As such, ideology is regarded as a function of society, a social practice that provides individuals with social and political identities that are embodied in social institutions and rituals that in turn bolster particular belief systems. It ultimately functions to secure the reproduction of a 'social formation' by effecting an 'imaginary' resolution of 'real' social antagonisms. (While I agree with Althusser that ideology functions to secure social reproduction despite real social antagonisms, I would question Althusser's view that these are always reducible to *class* antagonisms generated by the relations of production.)

Two aspects of Althusser's writings are relevant here: first, his account of the embodiment and enactment of ideology in material institutions; and second, his exposition of human subjectivity as a material effect of ideology through the function of the 'interpellative hail'.

IDEOLOGY AS MATERIAL PRACTICE

Althusser understands ideology as a fundamental force in the reproduction of society. It is a social 'practice' which produces human subjectivity, constitutes social and political identities, beliefs, and outlooks that are embodied

in social institutions and their attendant rituals. Ideology renders stable and seamless the social order; it functions to cover over discontinuities, discrepancies, and contradictions. So crucial is this political function, and so firmly does Althusser wish to insist upon its institutional materiality, that he makes the unusual and startling terminological move of designating ideology and its embodiments (church, family, media, etc.) as *part of the state* or in his terms 'the state apparatus'. Ideology binds together a social formation no less materially than do the police, courts, and army. It is in his account of the ISA that Althusser's account of subjectivity makes a compelling theoretical framework through which to interpret the workings of the TRC, a temporary institution that specifically constructed and called into being the subjects of political violence that underpinned and moralized South Africa's democratic transition.

In Althusser's (1993: 16–17) account, any perception of reality is always already an act of interpretation which draws upon and is legitimized by a prior collective discourse, which is itself produced by a combination of material and social conditions and institutionalized in ISAs.⁵ Ideology materializes through ritual practices that find their formal articulation in institutions. For example, religious practices appear to the believer and others as fundamentally an expression of an inner conviction: the Church is made manifest by its attendant rituals of, for example, baptism, confession and prayer; the ritualistic expressions of the institution make 'faith' external, material, observable. However, rituals are legitimized by the institution. They do not simply *reflect* an inner faith but are intrinsic to its material constitution. In Althusser's words, 'the existence of the ideas of [a subject's] belief is material in that his ideas are his material actions inserted into material practices governed by material rituals which are themselves defined by the material ideological apparatus from which derive the ideas of that subject' (p. 43). This point is nicely captured by Žižek (1994), who writes that ISAs 'designate the material existence of ideology in ideological practices, rituals and institutions . . . the "external" ritual performatively generates its own ideological foundation' (pp. 12–13). These insights into the relationship between ritual, faith and its institutionalization illuminate the way in which the TRC politicizes the outer enactment or performance of 'inner' psychological processes such as remorse, forgiveness, and reconciliation. The TRC is a material institution replete with 'tribunals', formal procedures and rituals. Althusser refers to Pascal's 'kneel and you will believe' which parallels the TRC's implicit 'testify, take part, follow our procedures, and you will be reconciled'. Moreover, the very notion of an Ideological *State* Apparatus seems particularly applicable to the TRC which was even in the most basic legalistic sense a state organization, established by South African law, with the explicit purpose of securing social unity and legitimizing the new regime through the deliberate construction of a new, inclusive, national identity.

THE IDEOLOGICAL INTERPELLATION OF SUBJECTS

The materialization of ideology in everyday life is manifest in Althusser's (1993) 'interpellative hail' through which human subjectivity is constituted (pp. 44–51). He argues that 'the category of the subject is only constitutive of all ideology insofar as all ideology has the function . . . of "constituting" concrete individuals as subjects' (p. 45). Following on from this, a double constitution takes place where the functioning of ideology is only extant in its functioning in the material forms of its existence, that is, embodied within the subject called into being by ideology. Central to this materialization is the process of 'recognition' by which the subject is brought into being. Althusser uses the example of two friends meeting in the street, one of whom addresses the other 'hello, my friend', and shakes his hand. Hand shaking and ritual addresses are material ritual practices 'of ideological recognition in everyday life' through which certain subjects – friends, acquaintances, colleagues – are recognized or 'interpellated' (p. 46). Ideology functions by 'transforming' concrete individuals into subjects through the operation of the interpellative hail where the materialization of ideology and the hailing or interpellation of individuals as subjects are simultaneous.⁶

The TRC can readily be understood as an ISA that interpellated South Africa's new political subjects through the legal documentation preceding the Commission, the Committees of the TRC and the ceremonies that attended the public performance of national reconciliation. Central to this performance were the subject categories of 'victim' and 'perpetrator' through which the new national ideology of reconciliation was materialized and enacted through the rituals of confession, forgiveness, and remorse. These rituals called into being their subjects who, by virtue of their recognition of the given subject categories, participated in a double subjection. Their recognition of the interpellative hail entails an acceptance of themselves within the order designated by the ideology of reconciliation. This requires, for example, an acceptance on the part of the 'victim' that a 'perpetrator' is not punished but granted amnesty in return for truth. And at the public hearings, 'perpetrators' were encouraged to make palpable shows of remorse and to seek forgiveness from victims.

'Victims' and 'perpetrators' were also institutionalized through the discrete Committees of the TRC to which they had to give testimony. The Amnesty Committee solicited, recorded, and processed 'perpetrator' testimonies, and the Human Rights Violations Committee did the same with 'victim' stories. As a result, those testifying had to decide to which Committee their evidence would be submitted on the basis of whether their submission was a 'victim' or 'perpetrator' submission which had to be decided *prior to* submission. In short, individuals had to decide *in advance of speaking to the TRC* whether they were speaking as 'victim' or 'perpetrator'. This fundamental division in the mechanisms of the Commission structured the identities of those submitting to its authority prior to public hearings which further reinforced these already established identities.⁷

NARRATING POLITICS

I turn now to the question of narrative, the internal structure of which performs precise disciplinary functions that are not captured by the analyses presented so far. Narrative, typically, imposes form upon its subjects – ‘victims’ and ‘perpetrators’ – and objects – ‘gross violations of human rights’ – because it arranges actions and events in a sequential and connected relationship and embeds them within a tri-partite temporal structure which consists of a well-marked beginning, middle and end. The works of Hayden White and Frank Kermode help to flesh out the ways in which an understanding of narrative *form* is fundamental to thinking through the politics of reconciliation in South Africa.

THE CONTENT OF THE FORM

White (1987) argues that narrative ‘entails ontological and epistemic choices with distinct ideological and even specifically political implications’ (p. ix). The effect of these ‘choices’ is to endow upon any narrated events an ‘illusory coherence’ that underpins a claim to a ‘secured knowledge of reality’ (White, 1978: 81). Narrative makes a claim on reality insofar as it feigns ‘to make the world speak itself and speak itself as a story’ (White, 1987: 2).

The correspondence effect – between narrative and reality – is embedded within narrative structure. Stories situate the actions of agents within a particular socio-political order and direct their actions towards an end point or closure which effects a summation of the overall ‘meaning’ of that depiction. Of course, no sequence of events really does just end or become resolved, so closure comes to signify the constructed transition ‘from one physical or social space to another’ (White, 1987: 23).

Closure provides the central principle by which a teleological significance is assigned to preceding events, with the effect that narrative transforms its subject(s) into a ‘totality evolving in time’ because it comprises a temporal unity that delineates a beginning, middle, and an end. This temporal unity underpins the claim to an ‘authentic’ representation of ‘what actually happened’ because in order to sustain the mimetic effect, the correspondence between the narrative and the real, events must, according to White (1987), be narrated according to the chronological ordering of their occurrence. They must also be narrated or ‘revealed as possessing a structure, an order of meaning, that they do not possess as mere sequence’, an effect secured by closure or resolution (p. 5). Narrative endows ‘reality’ upon the events related because the events appear, on the one hand, to be subordinated to a particular order of moral existence, and, on the other, to elicit meaning from their place within this order. For example, the TRC’s narration of a history of ‘gross violations of human rights’ perpetrated with a ‘political objective’ is subordinated to the principle of reconciliation, and violations elicit meaning from their place within the moral order that reconciliation (as

closure) institutes. Narrative ‘possesses a content prior to any given actualization of it in speech or writing, or rather a “content of the form”’ (p. ix), and it is this feature that secures its ideological effect, conditioning relations between events narrated by being *prior* to them.

White (1987) cites Hegel to suggest that historical narrative not only displays a particular form but also presupposes a particular content through which materializes a socio-political order or legal system ‘against which or on behalf of which the typical agents of a narrative account militate’ (p. 13). The questions of law, legitimacy, and authority are thus central to narrative, the closure of which exacts the force of a moral judgement on the events it relates. But what White does not illuminate in Hegel is the explicitly political question of the relationship of narrative to the state. Hegel (1956) notes that the appearance of the state as a continuous and stable entity is an *effect* of official historical narratives that document its emergence: ‘It is the State which first presents subject-matter that is not only *adapted* to the prose of History, but involves the production of such history in the very progress of its own being’ (p. 61). In Hegel’s view, narrative – ‘the prose of History’ – is fundamental to the production of the unity and continuity of the state, an endeavour to which the narrative of reconciliation in South Africa is also manifestly directed.

In general, White’s work investigates narrative as a universal ‘deep structure’ of historical consciousness and historical representation in order to disclose the repressions inherent in the construction of knowledge and authority that are, in part, an effect of narrative structure itself. In so doing, he reflects primarily upon historiography because, he argues, it provides an especially fruitful locus of any deliberation on narrative because narrative is the instrument ‘with which the conflicting claims of the imaginary and the real are mediated, arbitrated, or resolved in a discourse’ (White, 1987: 4).

This observation is pertinent to the politics of reconciliation which mediates a contest between the imperatives of the real and a desire for the imaginary. The TRC negotiated the relationship between the real – violent conflict – and the imaginary – future reconciliation – by narrating a causal and linear relationship between them. Its narrative was roughly organized around the following stages in its story: a past conditioned by violent conflict, a present marked by the confessional, and testimonial, and a future reconciliation.

In three important sections of the Report, the TRC (1998) narrates and re-narrates South Africa’s history, a history overwhelmingly conditioned by violence. The Report asserts the necessity of placing the investigated events within a broad historical context because the TRC ‘tells only a small part of a much larger story of human rights abuse in South and southern Africa’ (volume 1 (2) 4). It states that the wider story is conditioned by two main factors that shaped the national history: ‘violence and the law, and the relationship between them’ (volume 1 (2) 4).

The first of these accounts appears prominently as the ‘scene-setting’ chapter in the first volume, which recounts the political and historical

perspective within which 'gross human rights violations' during the investigated period from 1960 to 1994 took place. This narrative takes in almost 350 years of violations, reaching back to the mid-17th century. It is organized into three national historical 'phases': the first presenting a backdrop of three centuries of violent and oppressive practices in South Africa and focusing upon the struggle between the Afrikaners, of Dutch descent, and all other ethnic groups living in South Africa during this period. The second phase is marked by the inauguration of the National Party in 1948 which marked the formal instantiation of apartheid and investigates the violent foundations of its laws and regulations, while the third phase marks out the time span of the TRC's investigations beginning with the Sharpville Massacre in 1960 and ending with the legal inauguration of the TRC in 1994. This latter period is narrated as one of 'intensified conflict' and is portrayed primarily as a political contest between the National Party (NP) and the African National Congress (ANC).

By situating the mandated period within a historical context of violence reaching back around 300 years, the TRC narrates a linear, causal, and cumulative effect of the perpetration of gross human rights violations. The resultant and central political effect of this narrative is to render an account of the genesis of the South African nation that is commensurate with the origins of apartheid. The Report thus enters contentious historiographical debates about the inception of apartheid. The term 'apartheid' is often used to designate practices of governance and control originating 300 years ago as well as referring, more usually, to the laws and policies inaugurated by the National Party from 1948. The effect of its dual deployment, as Aletta Norval (1996: 1) notes, has been to make the history of apartheid 'coincide' with that of South Africa. The TRC acknowledges that the inauguration of the NP in 1948 represents an intensification and formalization of apartheid but not a departure from previous practices of governance. The effect of this is to suggest that the success of the NP in 1948 did not constitute a 'rupture' to a previously different political order, but by contrast, represented the continuation of a long history of violent oppression in which the NP were only recent protagonists. The *continuity* of violence governs the TRC's narration, authorizing the necessity of reconciliation.

The TRC's history conveys the message that 'violence has been the single most determining factor in South African political history', but that, and crucially, only a reconciliatory politics could provide the necessary moral and lasting closure of violence, the inauguration of which symbolized a new order of existence coinciding with transition to the new regime (TRC, 1998: 1 (2) 68). To the 'victims' of human rights violations, this narrative of truth and reconciliation offers the hope of deliverance from their traumatic experiences, and to the 'perpetrators', the narrative is a warning that contains, even although it does not enact, the possibility of retribution.

That the new regime in South Africa sought to re-narrate the past at all is testimony to a political contest in which *at least* two versions of the past could have been narrated. In the absence of such a contest, there would be no real reason to undertake the authority of rendering a 'true account' of

'what really happened'. The authority of the narrative rendered thus functions as 'the authority of reality itself' (White, 1987: 20).

THE SENSE OF AN ENDING

Kermode (2000) pushes an interpretation of closure further. He explores the ways in which apocalyptic fictions, or 'fictions of the end', condition our experience of living in time, where closure emerges out of crisis and is a response to the desire for order and meaning. For Kermode, crisis and closure are the conditioning features of narrative which itself functions as the fundamental discursive technology through which we make sense of the world and of our place within it.

Kermode suggests that 'the ending' conditions the unfolding of a story from its very beginning. He suggests that the end is *immanent* rather than simply imminent in the story itself because narrative emplotment 'imposes a meaning on the events that make up its story level by revealing at the end a structure that was immanent in the events all along' (p. 20). Reconciliation as the prefigured closure of transition thus shapes the new official history *from its very beginning* in both symbolic and material ways, both as an imaginary condition of co-existence, and as a disciplinary discursive construction.

Reconciliation as closure functions not only at the level of the official narrative told by the TRC, but as a powerful trope governing individual testimonies. Jeffrey Benzien, a former security policeman in the 1980s, stood before the TRC in 1996 to confess to killing Ashley Kriel and to torturing other ANC activists. He was present to tell the 'truth' about violent state security operations in exchange for amnesty. He related how he had developed a torture technique which became known as the 'wet bag', involving placing a wet cloth bag over the head of a restrained suspect and closing it tightly around the neck, and how he had used this technique in order to 'extract information' from Kriel among others. Benzien prefaced his confession with the following 'reconciliatory' declaration:

Firstly, I apologise to any person or persons whom I have harmed and I specifically apologise to the families of Ashley Kriel for the death of their son and brother . . . Life is precious and judged *ex post facto*, and based on today's political situation of reconciliation, his death was unnecessary . . . It is now reconciliation, forgive and forget at its best.⁸

Benzien's apology explicitly invokes reconciliation as the desired end point towards which his revelation is directed. In his testimony, Benzien mentions that the reconciliatory spirit in which he offered his 'truth' had been already reciprocated by some of Kriel's family members who had stated that they would not oppose his amnesty application. Reconciliation, thus, conditions and structures Benzien's 'confession'. Indeed, Benzien's testimony appears on first reading to resonate with White's understanding of narrative as a powerful system of meaning production 'by which individuals can be taught to live a distinctively "imaginary relation to their real conditions of

existence". The TRC's narrative conditioned individual testimonies to the TRC in order to make commensurate those accounts with the overall story about reconciliation it sought to tell. This had the effect of inculcating among many participants 'an unreal but meaningful relation' to the social formations of reconciliation in which they were 'indentured to live out their lives and realize their destinies as social subjects' (White, 1987: x).

However, Benzien implicitly indicates the contingency of South Africa's reconciliatory narrative, and knowingly implies that he might tell his story differently under different conditions. He states that his confession is made on the basis of 'today's political situation of reconciliation', and that 'it is now reconciliation', implicitly acknowledging the contingent political circumstances out of which a reconciliatory politics emerged. Benzien's witting manipulation of the TRC narrative is still, however, a demonstration of the disciplinary power of the official story, which he makes internal to his own account, as much as it is a subtle repudiation of it.⁹

Kermode's thesis allows us to see how reconciliation works back through the official narrative and conditions individual testimonies delivered to the TRC. Reconciliation works as an organizing category that seeks and imposes concordance in place of contestation, conditioning the way in which South Africa's history is related in symbolic and material ways; through the discourse of forgiveness at the public hearings, and through the negation of criminal trials in favour of amnesty, Reconciliation conditions what gets told and how. It demands a particular story about South Africa's past to be told, a story of a cleavage between or violent 'splitting' of 'two' communities that requires healing. It tells of what is past, violent conflict, what is passing, truth-revelation (confession) and remorse, and what is to come, reconciliation. Thus the past and present bear the mark of future narrative closure, of reconciliation. Reconciliation is thus a transformative fiction that confers a moral unity upon the related events.

Kermode acknowledges that the moral force of closure is thus in some way related to judgement as the hidden, organizing principle of narrative itself where, as White (1987) also notes, 'the "weight of meaning" of the events recounted is "thrown forward" onto a future just beyond the immediate present, a future fraught with moral judgement and punishment for the wicked' (p. 23). As such, the TRC figures reconciliation both as narrative closure but also as a principle of judgement that seeks concordance between contending perspectives on the past. In compensation for the irregularity and contingency of 'real life', 'justice is the human order we find or impose upon it' (Kermode, 2000: 105).

South Africa's past is, of course, irreducible to a single plot. But Kermode's analysis of narrative structuration is less deterministic than his explication of closure appears to allow because he argues that closure is continually marked and disrupted by the interplay between identity and difference (Kermode, 2000: 144). This is expressed as a conflict between the overall plot and individual contestations of the plot, such that what is of real interest is 'the conflict between the deterministic pattern any plot suggests, and the freedom

of persons within that plot to choose and so to alter the structure, the relations of beginning, middle, and end' (p. 30).

Indeed, 'real events' disrupt the coherence that narrative sanctifies because *they do not yield themselves as stories* but are *transformed into stories*. Every story entails the inclusion of particular events, and the exclusion of other events and accounts that do not fall within the narrative *telos*. Those excluded threaten to disturb the formal (moral) coherence of the story because no single narrative can contain the range of meanings it generates or forecloses. One notable contestation of the TRC's story which illustrates this dilemma deserves a mention here. Wynand Malan was originally appointed as commissioner to the TRC but withdrew because he objected to its premises. Malan's opposition to the TRC is included as a 'Minority Position' in the Report in which he argues against what he perceives as the TRC's antipathy to 'certain groups living within traditional or nationalist value systems who were party to the conflict', that is, NP supporters and agents (TRC, 1998: 5 (9)). Malan goes on to criticize the TRC's equation of 'reconciliation' with 'national unity', and specifically opposes the religious overtones of the TRC's work. He disputes the TRC's historical narrative by providing an alternative (NP) narrative of apartheid violence which, he argues, was justified by the 'need for security'. It is the convention of the 'Minority Position' deployed by the TRC which supports the possibility of making alternative narrative interventions that might be incongruent with, indeed generated by, the dominant story.

CONCLUSION

This interpretation of reconciliation in South Africa has sought to illuminate two related theoretical arguments that reveal its political workings. First, that reconciliation is an ideological system of meaning that constructs and makes 'real' the subjects and objects of the political processes it governs. And second, by incorporating a narrative analysis into the general frame of discourse analysis, this investigation shows how causality and connection between historical events and political processes are constructed and not 'found', and that what are assumed to be the regular continuities and assumptions of political life are in part an effect of their narrative representation. It shows what, discursively, is entailed in constructing reconciliation as a response to the conflict between the moral demands of justice and the political demands of peace – the dilemma with which the article began – a dilemma out of which many reconciliatory political projects to date have been conceived.

By combining the insights of discourse analytic and narrative approaches, this argument facilitates two fundamental political insights. First, it shows how reconciliation *constrains* in that it constructs power relations and is productive of political processes. Second, this combination of approaches allows an understanding of those moments where narrative *fails* to constrain, where there is a discrepancy between those who conform and those who do

not. These are moments that make apparent the way in which the TRC attempts to force a unity between conflictual and disparate elements of the story, as Benzien's testimony and Malan's refutation demonstrate.

Far from closing off the past, South Africa's reconciliation story produced new conflicts around its meaning. Since the TRC finished its work the political compromise upon which reconciliation was built has led to a contestation of financial reparations to victims, the promise of which was not properly fulfilled by the TRC. This has led to victim groups pursuing compensation against multinationals through courts in the United States, the outcome of which, at the time of writing, has yet to be determined. This case demonstrates one of the important ways in which the reconciliation projected by the TRC did not, could not, fully redeem the antagonisms of the past and indeed continues to generate new ones in 'post-reconciliation' South Africa.

NOTES

My thanks go to Martin McIvor for his invaluable comments on earlier drafts.

1. This formulation does not preclude the possibility that declarations by authoritative subjects are contestable and indeed contested in practice.
2. Foucault's account of subjection is extended further in his later writings and comprises a more elaborate account than I am able to present here. Foucault shows how human subjection is manifest differently according to particular historical configurations, the details of which are sketched out in Dreyfus and Rabinow (1982).
3. It is important to note that Foucault deliberately excludes the concept of ideology from his own analyses. His aversion to ideology is opposed to the general understanding that ideology stands in opposition to something else, for example, truth, because he refuses to adjudicate the truth or falsity of any particular discourse (Foucault, 1980: 118).
4. Nor are these continuities implausible to suppose given the shared intellectual milieu in which they were developed: David Macey (1994) records that Althusser and his key collaborator Etienne Balibar regarded Foucault's *The Order of Things* as helping to provide 'a general theory of ideology', while a brief flirtation of Foucault's with the terminology of 'Ideological State Apparatuses' reflected a reading of Althusser's influential essay (pp. 197, 300). Of course many may see Foucault's work as a project that develops and departs from that of Althusser in ways that surpass or subvert its original framework. But a contrary case can be made, as suggested by Žižek, that Foucault's insights can be put to more effective use if re-integrated with a revised or 'post-Althusserian' framework.
5. Althusser (1993) distinguishes between ISAs and Repressive State Apparatuses. ISAs cover religious institutions, educational bodies, the family, legal institutions, the political system and parties, trade unions, media, and cultural institutions. Repressive State Apparatuses 'function by violence' and include the government, administration, the army, the police, the courts, and prisons (pp. 16–17).
6. However, this would suggest a linear temporal fixing of the 'concrete individual' as prior to the subject. Althusser (1993) corrects his linear account by arguing that as ideology is 'eternal' it has always-already interpellated individuals

as subjects such that 'individuals are always-already subjects' even before they are born (p. 50).

7. While this may not seem problematic, in some cases this identity division was complex. For example, *askaris* were former ANC armed operatives who were captured by the state and 'turned' through torture into state security agents, fitting into both 'victim' and 'perpetrator' categories.
8. The hearing transcript can be found at: <http://www.doj.gov.za/trc/amntrans/ct3/benzien.htm>.
9. This is partly because the success of his amnesty application fell upon the narrative framing of his testimonial. For an excellent discussion of the narrative framing of amnesty accounts see Veitch (2001).

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